Asking a new member to participate in Freemasonry, the Lodge and its activities from their Initiation onwards will help them to learn and understand more about what we are, and to feel part of and more committed to the Lodge.

However, the level of participation should suit the circumstances, wishes and interests of the new member.

Indeed, there is fine line between encouraging participation and coercion.

The first has positive benefits while the second often leads to an early resignation. The distinction between the two is not always in the words or actions of the person supporting the new member, but rather in the manner in which they are conveyed and the way they are perceived by, and the effect they have on, the new.

This thread looks at how you can encourage participation in Lodge meetings, in visiting other Lodges and in social events.

PARTICIPATION IN LODGE MEETINGS

- Add the new member to the Lodges communication and social media channels, such as email distribution lists, WhatsApp groups, etc.
- You will have told the new member the dates of regular Lodge meetings during your early discussions about joining. Encourage them to add dates and times to their diary.
- Explain they should plan to arrive at least 30-minutes before the start time published on the summons, but that if family or work circumstances prevent them from doing so, they should still attend, albeit late, and will be just as welcome.
- Be alert to any issues about start times and potential clashes with work or family commitments.
- If new members do have difficulty with start times, review them and be prepared to adjust them to increase attendance.
- Help the new member make sense of the summons, the different information it contains and the implications for them.
- Point out in particular:
  - The importance of responding to a summons as soon as possible, including submitting apologies.
  - The importance of submitting meal choices and paying for meals when requested.
  - The implications of the dress code.
  - The meaning of different items of Lodge business and how the impact on the new member.
  - Whether or not they will be required to retire from the meeting while it conducts a degree that they have not yet taken.
- Accompany the new member at their early meetings, to introduce other members and regular visitors, and to answer their immediate questions.
- Help them feel comfortable during Lodge meetings by ensuring they have everything they need to participate, such as:
  - An appropriate Lodge or Metropolitan / Provincial / District tie.
  - The words to opening and closing odes, and other songs (including Grace).
  - Confidence in using signs, tokens and words, including the Sign of Fidelity during prayers.
  - The method of approving a motion, "according to the manner customarily used among Masons."
  - The method of addressing the Master and other members during an open Lodge.
- Arrange for someone to accompany them if they have to retire from the Lodge.
- Demonstrate good conduct in a Lodge and act as a role model.
- Enquire whether they would like to deliver part of the ritual at a forthcoming meeting and explain they will receive plenty of notice and help with the learning required.
- Enquire whether they would like to propose or respond to a toast at the Festive Board.

- If they have previously declined either of the above, remind them that they make subsequently offer to do so.
- At regular intervals, check how they think or feel they are progressing and whether they wish to progress at a faster or slower pace.
- Explain to them the different activities undertaken in the Lodge and the routes they can follow, or special interests they could develop.
- Enquire whether they would like to learn more about, or help with, any of these activities and make suitable arrangements with the officers involved.
- Keep in contact during breaks between Lodge meetings, especially any extended summer breaks. Research in one Province indicates that candidates who are Initiated between January and June are less likely to remain in membership than those Initiated between September and December, largely because of the reduced participation.
- Keep all of the above under review at intervals and seek the support or assistance of other members of the Lodge as necessary.

BENEFITS OF VISITING

Research undertaken by the Membership Focus Group (MFG) highlighted the benefits to new members of visiting other Lodges. It produced evidence that those new members who visit from an early stage are more likely to build their commitment to Freemasonry and remain in membership.

The benefits to the new member include:

- A chance to reflect on what the member them self may have experienced very recently
- Increased familiarisation with the ceremonies
- Opportunities to learn about Lodge practices and protocols
- An appreciation of and respect for the similarities and differences between Lodges
- A wider network of new friends, and possibly discovering existing friends who are already Freemasons
- Increased confidence
- A chance to visit a special interest or affiliation Lodge with which they might have something in common
- An opportunity to build Freemasonry into their lifestyle at a level that suits them, especially if their own Lodge meets infrequently.

GUIDANCE WHEN ACCOMPANYING A NEW MEMBER ON A LODGE VISIT

- *Encourage new members to visit and offer to attend with them*, without suggesting that visiting is required or coercing them to visit beyond their own capabilities or resources of time and money.
- *Before making a visit, explain to the new member*:
    - How to book to visit another Lodge, including local contact arrangements
    - The importance of booking by the Lodge's booking deadline
    - How to check a summons for timings, dress code, ceremonies, etc.
- *Accompany a new member on their early visits*, travelling with them if possible.
- *On arrival at the Lodge being visited,* explain:
    - How to pay for the meal
    - How to obtain EAF & FCF regalia
    - Signing in using the Tyler's Book.
- *Before the Lodge opens,* explain:
    - Seating arrangements in a Lodge
    - Singing of opening and closing odes
    - Making sure not to vote on resolutions before the Lodge
    - The procedure when retiring from a Lodge about to work in a higher degree, and returning afterwards
    - Giving greetings, if this is done in the Lodge
    - Advising them to make note of particular points they could mention if asked to respond to the visitors' toast.
- *During the Lodge*, sit with them, or seat them with another friend, and act as a role model in matters such as not speaking during ceremonies, giving salutes, etc.
- *After the Lodge has closed,* remain with the new member rather than join any procession, accompany them to the bar and the festive board, introduce them to members of the Lodge and other Freemasons at a similar stage to them.
- *At the festive board:*
    - Sit with them so that you can explain the practices of the specific Lodge and how it differs from their own.
    - Demonstrate firing, respect for the gavel and other matters of practice and protocol.
    - Remind them to remain seated during the toast to the visitors.
    - Ensure they have the words to any songs being sung.
    - Answer any questions about the various proceedings.

LODGE SOCIAL EVENTS

- "Engaging through social and community events" has much to say about the benefits of Lodge socials for attracting new members and their families.
- Lodge social events broaden the satisfaction that can be gained from Freemasonry, by bringing together members with a common bond and their families in an enjoyable environment.
- They also create opportunities for members to contribute something different to the Lodge.
- Many new members will have experienced Lodge social events as a guest when they were considering whether to apply to join.
- Encourage new members to attend their Lodge social events as often as they can, either because it is something they know they will enjoy or to support those who have arranged the event.
- Identify any planning and organisation skills that a new member could contribute towards Lodge social events.
- Encourage them to suggest ideas for other events, to broaden the range of events on offer.
- Involve partners and family members as members of social committees and as event organisers.